

Pastoral Letter: The armed conflict in Ukraine.

Feb 11/24 2022, Thursday. Hieromartyr Blaise (+ C. 316).

St Nicholas Orthodox Church
708 S Chestnut, McKinney TX 75069
<http://www.orthodox.net>

Dear Brothers and Sisters:

We all share the most important identity. We are Orthodox Christians. As such, we consider all Orthodox Christians to be our brothers and sisters, as we share the most fundamental identity: we are, via baptism, co-members of the one body of Christ. All other ways we may identify ourselves, such as our country, race, ethnicity, language, politics, gender, etc., must be subservient to our core identity.

We are of varied nationalities by our first birth, but by our second birth (from above), we are Orthodox Christians in the Russian Orthodox Church. This state of being is not dependent on the country one was born in, the language one speaks, or anything else; we are children of the church and strugglers for virtue and truth. There are differences in customs and politics that some of us would not understand, but they are secondary to the similarities that bind us. Of course, all of us are aware that there are Orthodox Christians in Russia, Ukraine, and everywhere in the world who do not live as faithful Christians and do not live according to Christian morality and thinking. That does not negate the truth, known in heaven, that Orthodox Christians in Ukraine and Russia, and indeed, all people everywhere, are loved by God equally and are of equal worth in His eyes.

We live in perilous times, and there is a legion of dangers in Ukraine and Russia. Bombing has already begun in Ukraine, and therefore the horrors of war are happening in that God-blessed country. These soon,

likely, will be exported to Russia as Ukrainian forces respond. Perhaps other countries will be openly involved in hostilities. There will be manipulators in the shadows. In war, there are always secret agitators that benefit. We may read and listen to the news and form political opinions. Still, we must make all of our apparent knowledge subservient to the fundamental truth that we are Orthodox Christians. We must not rejoice in any bloodshed or suffering for anyone. Some of us may know the languages of the countries involved, but this does not make our knowledge superior because all news and politics are a mixture of truth and lies.

There is something that is not a lie; people in Ukraine and Russia will suffer. Russians and Ukrainians, Orthodox and non-Orthodox, children and fathers and mothers and soldiers - will suffer, some will be wounded grievously, and some will die. It is winter in Ukraine, and anyone made homeless because of bombing or hostilities will suffer much. Every death, every orphan, and every drop of suffering because of armed conflict – is a tragedy.

In our parish, we have been praying openly for Ukraine for many years and for over a year have included prayers for Metropolitan Unuphry and his much suffering flock in all of our primary services, Vespers, Matins, and the Divine Liturgy. Along with prayers for Ukraine, we always also pray for Russia. Our prayers for these countries are not that one would

be victorious in armed conflict, but that God's mercy would be upon them and that there would be peace and prosperity for everyone. Our concept of prosperity is not material wealth or comfort, but that for all, there would be physical and spiritual safety and peace in the soul because God is active in our deep heart.

Archbishop Peter wishes to remind us that: "the phrase 'the God-preserved Russian Land,' as found in our Divine Services, is always meant to include all Slavic people that owe their Orthodoxy to the apostolic ministries of the Great Prince Vladimir. In Church Slavonic, the word used is 'Rosiskii,' not 'Russkii.' Those two words are significantly different, but some may not understand this difference. The first, Rosiskii, refers to all of the people of Rus: Russians, Byelorussians, Ukrainians, and Carpatho Russians. This is greater than any present geographic boundaries. It encompasses all people of St. Vladimir's dominion – not just Russia."

In all Slavic churches, Russians pray for Ukrainians and Ukrainians for Russians, Byelorussians for Ukrainians and Russians, etc., etc. In corporate prayer, we all lift our voices: "For the God preserved Russian Land (all Slavic lands) and its Orthodox people both in the homeland and in the diaspora, and for their salvation, let us pray to the Lord."

There is a natural human tendency to take sides when there is a significant conflict, and war is among the most terrible of all conflicts. I'm not taking sides because I cannot know the truth about all the political rhetoric, news, and social commentary. There are people in the shadows manipulating things both in Russia and Ukraine. There are wolves in the church (!) manipulating things. Some governments are manipulating things. There is partisanship that causes people to believe things and do things.

The partisanship that should most greatly motivate us is that we are Christians and that we must pray.

There will be much anger, and there will be much news, and very little of it will be profitable to the soul. There will be those who suffer as politicians speak and armies move, commentators give opinions, and propaganda machines work feverishly to manipulate. I would beg you not to take sides either, in terms of believing one side to be evil and the other good. You might have a political opinion, and God bless you for that. It is your right to have an informed opinion, but remember that we are Christians, and our faith must inform all of our views.

I am asking (not commanding) you to be sparse in your public opinions, except that we should urge one another to pray. Archbishop Peter has expressed this same sentiment in a letter to his clergy. Politics at the end of a gun is always ugly and deadly. Whether we think the cause is just or unjust, it is a terrible thing when a gun is fired at a human being, or a bomb explodes.

Archbishop Peter has sent a letter (https://chicagodiocese.org/news_220224_1.html), in which he tells us: "I strongly recommend that all the faithful of our Mid-American Diocese, every man, woman, and child, read this prayer (below) before your icons daily, and ask St. Vladimir's prayers before our Lord for a peaceful outcome to the present crisis."

He also has directed: "In all parishes of the Mid-American Diocese on Sunday, February 14/27, 2022, a special collection will be taken that will benefit the refugees and the other innocents suffering from the present military conflict. We urge our parishioners to be zealous in their support of those suffering. Their need is great, as is our opportunity to help them. All funds gathered will be forwarded to Metropolitan Onuphry of Kiev and All Ukraine so that he can use these funds to benefit those in the greatest need."

I'm asking everyone in the parish to also do 12 prostrations (if you cannot do a prostration, then do

what you can do, such as a bow from the waist or even just the sign of the cross) daily, with the following prayer or something similar to it: “Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy upon all of those in Russia and Ukraine.” I encourage you to pray additionally in any way that seems good to you, such as singing the Akathist to the Theotokos or any other akathists or canons. You may also want to take your prayer rope and pray a set number of Jesus prayers for those in Ukraine and Russia.

We will be scheduling regular molebens to pray for Russia and Ukraine. The first one will be Friday evening. We will add this prayer to all of our molebens

I’m aware that many have families living where there is war or the threat of war. Please remember to pray for those that you know by name every day. If you submit their names to us, we will certainly commemorate them in the Divine Liturgy and add their names to the petitions when we pray molebens during this time of war.

If you are angry or confused, have lost a loved one, or are anxious, talk to us! It is natural to have strong emotions during times of war. It is not a sin to have emotions, but we must always translate our feelings into intense prayer.

Archpriest Seraphim and Priest Nicholas

Links:

Statement from Archbishop Peter on the Crisis in Ukraine.

https://chicagodiocese.org/news_220224_1

PRAYER TO THE HOLY PRINCE VLADIMIR, EQUAL OF THE APOSTLES (English and Slavonic)

http://stvladimiraami.org/pamphlets/prayertostvladimir_dcma.pdf

This letter.

http://www.orthodox.net/announcements/pastoral-letter_2022-02-24.doc

http://www.orthodox.net/announcements/pastoral-letter_2022-02-24.pdf

PRAYER TO THE HOLY PRINCE VLADIMIR, EQUAL OF THE APOSTLES

http://stvladimiraami.org/pamphlets/prayertostvladimir_dcma.pdf

O great favorite of God, Prince Vladimir, Equal of the apostles! Thou didst reject the false belief and impiety of the pagans. And, having received holy baptism, with the light of divine faith and piety thou didst illumine the whole land of Kievan Rus. Thou art our first leader to the Lord Jesus Christ, the Author and Accomplisher of our everlasting salvation; thou art the fervent intercessor and mediator for the civil authorities, the Christ-loving armed forces, and for all the people. O our all-good father and enlightener: look down upon our infirmities and entreat the all-merciful King of heaven, that he be not exceeding wroth with us; that He not destroy us in our

iniquities, that He deliver us from internecine conflict; that He plant in our hearts the saving fear of Him; that He illumine our minds with His grace; and that we may understand the ways of the Lord. Entreat God Who loveth mankind, that He deliver us from the invasion of enemies, from internal strife, sedition and upheavals, and from every evil; that He grant us to have love one for another and oneness of mind, and that, living thus in peace on earth, we may be counted worthy with thee of the blessings of heaven, praising and exalting God supremely forever. Amen.

МОЛИТВА СВЯТОМУ РАВНОАПОСТОЛЬНОМУ КНЯЗЮ ВЛАДИМИРУ

О, великий угодниче Божий, равноапостольный княже Владимире! Ты отринул еси зловерие и нечестие языческое, и восприяв святое крещение просветил еси светом Божественных веры и благочестия всю страну киевския Руси. Ты еси первый вождь наш к Начальнику и Совершителю нашего вечного спасения Господу Иисусу Христу: ты еси теплый молитвенник и ходатай, о народоправителях, и христолюбивом воинстве и о всех людех. О, всеблагий отче и просветителю наш! Призри на немощи наша и умоли милосердаго Царя Небесного, да не прогневается на ны зело, да не

погубит нас со беззаконными нашими, и да избавит нас от междоусобных брани, и да всадит в сердце наше спасительный страх Свой, да просветит Своею благодатию ум наш, во еже разумети нам пути Господни. Моли, Человеколюбца Бога, да избавит нас от нашествия иноплемennых, от внутренних нестроений, мятежей и раздоров, и от всякого зла: да подаст нам, любовь между собою и единомыслие имети, да тако поживше в мире на земли, сподобимся с тобою вечного блаженства, хваляще и превозносяще Бога во веки веков. Аминь.